

STAGE ONE • SELF-AWARENESS & CAREER CLARITY

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage One • Self-Awareness & Career Clarity

PURPOSE

A generic icebreaker (“two truths and a lie,” name-and-a-fun-fact) burns five to ten minutes without doing any real work for the session that follows. These openers are different: each one is built directly from Stage One's actual content, so the warm-up itself starts the cognitive work the session needs — distinguishing values from preferences, questioning industry assumptions, recognizing that productivity advice isn't one-size-fits-all.

There is exactly one icebreaker per session, meant to run in the first eight to ten minutes before the session's first FIRST begins. Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right warm-up for what comes next.

Three Openers, One Per Session

SESSION 1

Two Truths and a Value

TIME: 10 min

1. Each person writes down two things they genuinely value (e.g., “I’d rather be broke and honest than rich and compromised”) and one thing that sounds like a value but is actually just a preference dressed up (e.g., “I value having a corner office”).
2. In pairs or small groups of three, each person shares all three without saying which is which.
3. The group guesses which one is the fake value. Facilitator debriefs: what made the fake one detectable? (Usually it’s tied to status or convenience rather than principle.)

WHY THIS WORKS

This gets people laughing while doing the exact cognitive work FIRST 01 requires — distinguishing genuine values from dressed-up preferences — before the more serious individual work begins.

SESSION 2

Career Rumor Mill

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask the group: “What’s one thing you’ve heard about your target industry that you’re not sure is actually true?” (e.g., “I heard consulting is all 80-hour weeks,” “I heard startups don’t do performance reviews.”)
2. Go around quickly, one rumor per person, no elaboration needed.
3. Facilitator doesn’t fact-check yet — just collects them on a whiteboard or shared doc. Reference the list later during FIRST 08 (Industry Insight) as things worth verifying against real research.

WHY THIS WORKS

Surfaces exactly the kind of stereotype-based assumption FIRST 08’s Common Pitfalls warns against, and turns it into a natural, low-stakes group activity rather than a lecture point.

SESSION 3

Productivity Confessions

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask: “What’s one productivity hack you’ve tried that completely didn’t work for you, even though it works for everyone else?”
2. Quick round-robin, one sentence each. Encourage genuine, slightly embarrassing honesty (e.g., “I tried the 5am wake-up thing for two weeks and was useless all day”).
3. Facilitator notes the theme: what works is genuinely personal, which is exactly what this session’s FIRSTS (14–18) are about to help each person figure out for themselves.

WHY THIS WORKS

Normalizes that generic advice doesn't work for everyone, which directly primes the session's core message: personality, work style, thinking style, and learning style are genuinely individual, not one-size-fits-all.